



A Few Regrets

On my 70th birthday, I can perhaps indulge in some recollections and share a few indelible memories with readers.

What I've chosen to share tends to be in the category of regrets. However, even today I am not sure how I could have handled things differently.

Networking in the era of PCs

I was involved in preparing a solution for a financial services company. The basic documents were spreadsheets.

My whole presentation was based on a workflow of sharing information. I had barely got started before the technical expert/consultant for the client interrupted me. He said that, typically, financial consultants kept their data and analysis sheets close to their chests. They would not use the system if they ever feared that their data/spreadsheets could be shared with others.

The presentation was obviously a disaster, and I cut it as short as I could.

Agile in the era of Waterfall

It was a big project. After the project was signed off, my role was more of an unwanted consultant to the development team, which was focused on the specifications. I tried to convince the team leader not to take the specs too literally. The client had only a vague understanding of how the computer software would help; so to me, it seemed better to interpret their requirements instead of getting signoffs on the specifications. I did not succeed.

However, on the side, I asked a junior programmer on the bench to use a reporting tool (similar to SQL for relational databases) to create *ad hoc* reports for the client. She became an expert at it within a week, and was in very high demand with the client. Many of these reports happily became a part of the specifications.

The essence of the system's utility lay in sharing data across sites. This was important, given that the leased lines worked at 1200 to 4800 baud at best and

were frequently down. Standard networking systems just would not work. Hence, it was necessary to write some tools to transfer the minimal data, reliably, in the background. However, this was not a part of the specs, and nothing in the project explicitly mentioned that the value of the project lay in the availability of data across the network.

I went for an annual vacation and upon my return was no longer associated with the project.

Just as well!

Shared libraries in the era before ego-less coding

There was a project I inherited, which was delayed. Just a couple of reports needed to be completed.

My heart sank when I had my first meeting with the group. The problem report was that a balance sheet was not balancing. How could a computer report not balance? The data could be wrong but any design would ensure that it was consistent. Not unexpectedly, the client cancelled the order a short while later.

However, I found that some of the code in the project could be reused. So, that became my goal for a prototype our group was creating. The project team did not believe it was possible because the utility core, which probably had come from a project in the US, had been contaminated with quick fixes for the failed project. The team worked on the prototype and I, in my spare time, cleaned up the utility library base and simplified its usage API, including by passing project-specific functions as parameters. The library was in a shape to be used for client projects as well. I talked to my manager.

Another group was also starting on a project. I suggested that both projects should use the same set of libraries. I had a meeting with the manager of the other project as well as my own manager. The former did not agree to my suggestion. He felt I was undermining him and said that his team was following a similar process. I readily